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Department of Psychology

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FOSTERING CREATIVITY: HR PRACTICES, WORK ENGAGEMENT, PERSONALITY AND AUTONOMY

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INTRODUCTION

In today's economic and organisational landscape, characterised by increasing complexity, market globalisation and extremely rapid technological change, organisations find themselves having to constantly redefine their criteria for effectiveness and survival (Wright et al., 2005). In this unstable environment, traditional management models – historically focused on the standardisation of processes and on the mere execution of tasks by staff – prove to be incomplete and insufficient to guarantee a sustainable competitive advantage (Prieto et al., 2012). The most recent
has amply demonstrated that the most valuable and strategic resource for modern organisations is **human capital** and, specifically, the ability of employees to exhibit innovative, proactive and flexible behaviour (Kooij et al., 2022).

In this context, the construct of **creativity** in the workplace has taken on a role of primary importance for the survival of business systems, having been identified as the crucial antecedent of any innovation process (Amabile, 1983). In the field of organisational psychology, creativity is defined as the ability to generate ideas, procedures or solutions that are original, innovative and potentially useful to the organisation (Amabile & Pratt, 2016; Zhou & George, 2001). It constitutes one of the fundamental drivers of organisational change and adaptation. Despite growing attention to the subject, the mechanisms through which organisations actually manage to foster employee creativity have long remained unclear, constituting what the literature has termed a veritable 'black box' of strategic human resource management (Cropanzano et al., 2017).

This study, based on the scientific work of Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), aims to examine the psychological and organisational processes that foster individual creative performance. Specifically, the analysis aims to explore the role of opportunity-enhancing human resource practices **(OEHR**) in generating a positive motivational spiral, as reflected in the construct of *work engagement* (Schaufeli et al., 2019).

Drawing on the **Conservation of Resources Theory** (COR Theory; Hobfoll, 1989) and an interactionist perspective on creativity (Amabile & Pratt, 2016), the theoretical model examined also highlights how the relationship between HR practices, engagement and creativity is influenced both by individual characteristics, such as **proactive** personality (Bateman & Crant, 1993), and by contextual factors linked to job design, such as **autonomy at work** (Morgeson & Humphrey, 2006).

This thesis is structured in three parts:

Chapter One will explore **the theoretical framework**, tracing the evolution of job design models and examining the key constructs relating to creativity. This is intended to help the reader gain an in-depth understanding of the variables under consideration and comprehend the rationale behind the authors' decision to conduct this research.

Chapter Two presents a **critical summary of the study**, focusing on a detailed analysis of the article by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), exploring its objectives and hypotheses, the research methodology, describing the participants, the sampling procedures, the standardised measurement instruments used, the data analysis strategy, the statistical findings, and the resulting theoretical and practical implications, as well as limitations for future research

- **Chapter Three** presents a discussion of the relevance of the publication **in the context of the course of study,** with reference to the subjects of Occupational Psychology and Theories and Tools for Personnel Management and Development

CHAPTER 1 – THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

1.1 The AMO model and human resource management methodologies

Within the field of organisational and industrial psychology, the study of Human Resource Management (HRM) practices focuses on the direct link between human resource management systems and employee performance. As highlighted by Wright and colleagues (2005), organisations do not achieve results through isolated individual activities, but through the application of coherent sets of practices. These practices trigger tangible changes in employees' attitudes and behaviours, thereby enhancing overall human capital.

To categorise these systems and understand how they determine work performance, the literature consistently employs the AMO paradigm. According to the original formulation by Appelbaum and colleagues (2000), the ability-motivation-opportunity (AMO) paradigm posits that individual employee performance does not depend on a single isolated factor, but is the combined and interconnected result of three
macro-dimensions managed by the organisation.

The first component is ability, which refers to all those HR practices aimed at ensuring that employees possess the knowledge, aptitudes and skills necessary to carry out their duties effectively. The second dimension concerns motivation, which encompasses all practices designed to incentivise and stimulate employees' commitment, operating on both an economic and a psychological level through reward systems, performance-related bonuses and formal performance recognition programmes. Finally, the third component consists of opportunities for participation, which focuses on creating a working environment structured to offer employees the necessary scope for manoeuvre, channels of communication to express their ideas, and direct involvement in corporate decision-making processes.

Within this theoretical framework, the article by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024) highlights how, although the three dimensions must operate in a coordinated manner, research attention should focus specifically on Opportunity-Enhancing Human Resource Practices (OEHR), as these are considered particularly relevant for promoting organisational creativity. The distinctive feature of OEHRs lies in their specific mode of operation at the organisational system level. Unlike practices centred on ability and motivation, which focus on the psychological characteristics of the employee, OEHRs act upon the organisational structure and the working environment to foster operational autonomy. (Appelbaum et al., 2000). This subset of practices redefines the very architecture of tasks and the ways in which work is carried out, transferring decision-making power and operational control from management to employees.

In practical terms, practices aimed at enhancing opportunities translate into specific and measurable management actions: the introduction of formal systems for employee involvement, the organisation of work based on self-managed teams, flexibility in working hours and tasks, and the establishment of two-way channels for sharing organisational information. By altering the structure of the working environment and ensuring that employees

effective access to information and decision-making resources, OEHR practices do not merely require employees to carry out tasks; rather, they remove organisational constraints and create the structural conditions necessary for staff to exhibit behaviours oriented towards flexibility, problem-solving and, specifically, creative performance (Appelbaum et al., 2000).

1.2 The construct of Work Engagement and its link to OEHR

Within the organisational psychology literature, work engagement is a key construct for explaining employees' well-being and motivation. Work engagement is formally defined as a positive, gratifying mental state linked to work, characterised by stability and pervasiveness (Schaufeli et al., 2002). Engagement is therefore a stable psychological and energetic disposition that encompasses the employee's entire professional experience, going beyond a focus on individual tasks or temporary behaviours.

According to the analysis conducted by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), this psychological state acts as a crucial internal activation factor. Organisational stimuli do not generate immediate innovation, but require psychological mediation to transform external investment into task-focused energy. Work engagement acts as an energy driver: a state of activation that drives the individual to voluntarily invest their resources in their work, going beyond the purely executional dimension.

The multidimensional nature of work engagement is operationally divided into three distinct yet closely interlinked components, which describe the employee's investment of physical, cognitive and emotional resources in the workplace (Schaufeli et al., 2002). The first dimension is vigour, the energetic and behavioural component of the construct, which involves high energy and resilience in carrying out tasks, combined with the willingness to sustain persistent physical and cognitive efforts, even in the face of operational difficulties. The second dimension is dedication, which represents the affective and emotional component. Dedication translates into a strong psychological commitment to one's work, accompanied by a deep sense of meaning, enthusiasm, inspiration, pride and a perception of stimulating challenge. Finally, the third dimension is absorption, which expresses the cognitive component. Absorption represents a state of total concentration and immersion in work, where time passes quickly and the

employee finds it difficult to interrupt their activities. (Schaufeli et al., 2002). Within the theoretical model analysed, the interaction of these three dimensions generates the high level of psychological activation essential for the worker to go beyond their role-related tasks, channelling cognitive and emotional resources into innovative behaviours and the generation of creative ideas.

A central theoretical and methodological aspect of the framework proposed by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024) lies in the need to distinguish work engagement from other related constructs in organisational psychology. The scientific literature has amply demonstrated that work engagement does not overlap with dimensions such as integration into work, workaholism, job satisfaction or organisational commitment (Gürbüz, Van Woerkom, et al., 2024; Halbesleben & Wheeler, 2008; Salanova et al., 2014).

The theoretical assumption that opportunity-enhancing practices (OEHR) act as the direct antecedent of work engagement is systematically explained within the Conservation of Resources (COR) Theory, formalised by Hobfoll (1989). According to this psychological paradigm, individuals are constantly motivated to protect, accumulate and increase their reserves of resources, both personal and contextual. Within the workplace, OEHR practices – such as the granting of decision-making autonomy, involvement in problem-solving processes and access to transparent information flows – do not function merely as administrative procedures, but constitute genuine external work resources (Hobfoll, 1989).

In the model proposed by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), an employee's exposure to these sets of structural practices triggers a positive spiral of resource accumulation. When the organisation offers genuine opportunities for participation and room for manoeuvre, it reduces the impact of bureaucratic constraints and provides employees with the contextual tools to exercise control over their own work. This increase in environmental resources generates an immediate psychological impact: employees feel valued and supported by the organisation, experiencing an increase in their resilience and emotional engagement. Consequently, in line with the tenets of COR theory, the accumulation of work resources resulting from OEHRs leads to the activation of work engagement, providing staff with the energy, emotional attachment and cognitive focus necessary to manage the complexity of their tasks (Hobfoll, 1989).

1.3 From the Social Exchange Perspective to the Conservation of s (COR) Theory

Within the field of organisational behaviour, the link between HR practices and employees' responses has historically been interpreted through Social Exchange Theory (SET). This perspective is based on the principle of reciprocity, according to which employees feel obliged to reciprocate the benefits received from the organisation by increasing their commitment. However, when the analysis shifts to complex, extra-role performances such as creative performance, the social exchange model reveals significant theoretical limitations, as it reduces the initiation of innovative behaviours to a mere contractual obligation or a relational barter (Cropanzano et al., 2017).

To move beyond this approach and understand the actual motivational processes, Gürbüz and colleagues (2024) adopt the Conservation of Resources (COR) Theory, formalised by Hobfoll (1989), as their frame of reference. Within this framework, HR practices aimed at enhancing opportunities (OEHR) are not to be understood as favours bestowed by management that must be reciprocated, but rather as structural and contextual workplace resources.

The impact of OEHRs therefore does not generate a sense of indebtedness in the employee, but triggers a 'spiral of resource gain' (Hobfoll, 1989). Access to information flows, participation in decision-making and team autonomy introduce external resources into the work context that counteract bureaucratic constraints and reduce stress.
The build-up of these energy reserves directly fuels the employee's psychological resources, resulting in a state of work engagement. Task commitment, therefore, is not the result of a norm of reciprocity, but the natural consequence of a positive motivational spiral in which a surplus of work-related resources enables the individual to fully express vigour, dedication and absorption (Hobfoll, 1989).

1.4 The contingency approach: the interaction between individual factors (Proactivity) and contextual s (Autonomy)

As previously explained, opportunity-enhancing practices (OEHR), which draw on the AMO model, are aimed at increasing the psychological state of work engagement, which in turn acts as the primary driver for sustaining individual creative performance. However, in the reality of organisational contexts,

this causal flow does not manifest itself in an identical and universal manner for all workers. In the moderated mediation model proposed by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), the authors investigate whether the effective translation of resources into innovative behaviours depends on the combined influence of two key variables: proactive personality and work autonomy.

The first influencing factor operates at the individual level and is identified as proactive personality. This construct describes a stable trait disposition to identify environmental opportunities, show initiative and act intentionally to modify the surrounding context (Bateman & Crant, 1993). It is essential to distinguish proactivity from the Big Five traits: whilst the latter describe adaptive tendencies, proactive personality is the only orientation geared towards intentional change and the active manipulation of the environment. Within the model, it operates **by amplifying** the employee's ability to transform the structural opportunities provided by the organisation into a deep and focused psychological commitment: the proactive worker does not passively endure working conditions, but utilises the energetic drive of work engagement to go beyond prescribed tasks and tolerate the risk inherent in experimenting with new ideas (Bateman & Crant, 1993).

For this personal drive to translate into genuine innovative behaviour, a second and decisive contextual condition linked to task design must be in place: work autonomy. Whilst proactive personality answers the question 'who can initiate the process', autonomy answers the question 'when can this connection actually materialise', acting as an indispensable contextual **moderator**. Defined as the degree of freedom and discretion granted to the employee in planning their time and choosing operational procedures (Hackman and Oldham, 1976), autonomy represents the concrete possibility of taking action. In the model proposed by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024), job autonomy works closely with psychological engagement to predict creativity. Even in the case of a highly motivated and proactive employee, the generation of original solutions would be nipped in the bud if hindered by over-regulated tasks or rigid bureaucratic constraints. Consequently, only when autonomy removes contextual barriers can high levels of engagement be channelled, free from structural impediments, into the formulation of ideas that are useful and innovative for the organisation (Hackman and Oldham, 1976)

1.5 Limitations of previous evidence and the current 'turning point' by Gurbuz et al. (2024)

The literature review conducted in this chapter enables us to map out precisely the evolutionary trajectory that has characterised the study of human resource management systems in relation to employee performance. Traditionally, research has operated within the AMO paradigm and Social Exchange Theory, consistently demonstrating how packages of organisational practices positively influence employees' attitudes and work-related behaviours (Appelbaum et al., 2000; Prieto et al., 2012). Nevertheless, when the focus shifts to individual creative performance, the linear models of the past prove to be incomplete, leaving the complex 'black box' that links organisational architecture to the generation of innovative ideas partially unexplored (Villajos et al., 2019; Wright et al., 2005).

Consequently, the main limitations identified in the previous literature can be divided into two levels. On the one hand, the psychological and behavioural mechanisms through which HR practices stimulate creativity have long remained obscure (the *'how'* question); on the other, there has been a tendency to overlook the role played by individual and task-design contingencies (the *'when'* question), applying universal and undifferentiated formulas to heterogeneous samples. Furthermore, the vast majority of previous studies have suffered from structural methodological limitations, relying on purely cross-sectional research designs incapable of capturing trends and changes in work attitudes over time.

It is against this backdrop that the scientific contribution of the target article by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024) fits, extending and enriching organisational theory in three fundamental respects. Firstly, moving beyond the logic of contractual reciprocity, the authors adopt the Conservation of Resources (COR) Theory to demonstrate that opportunity-oriented practices (OEHR) act as environmental resources capable of triggering a positive feedback loop, formally identified as *work engagement*. Secondly, the study addresses the need for a contingent and interactionist approach by simultaneously examining two crucial contextual conditions: proactive personality (a worker characteristic) and job autonomy (a task characteristic), highlighting how motivational energies require a synergy between intrinsic drive and structural leeway to translate into creative performance. Finally, from a methodological perspective, the research overcomes the limitations of cross-sectional designs by adopting a

longitudinal study comprising three waves spaced over time (*a three-wave lagged survey design*), providing a rigorous and robust empirical test of the hypothesised causal relationships.

CHAPTER 2 – STUDY BY GURBUZ ET AL (2024)

2.1 Research Objectives and Hypotheses

The empirical study conducted by Gürbüz and colleagues (2024) aims to shed light on the mechanisms within the 'black box' linking strategic human resource management to individual creative performance. Although previous literature has documented the effectiveness of high-engagement HR systems on work performance, the psychological understanding of *how* and *when* such practices stimulate creativity in the workplace still lacked structured interpretative frameworks.

To fill this research gap, the authors developed and tested a moderated mediation model based on the tenets of the Conservation of Resources (COR) Theory and the interactionist perspective on creativity. The primary objective is to test whether the causal pathway linking opportunity-focused HR practices (OEHR) and performance in creative tasks is mediated by the motivational state of *work engagement*. Secondly, the study aims to investigate the structural and individual contextual conditions of this process, examining the moderating roles played by proactive personality and work autonomy. Based on this theoretical framework, the research structures its investigative focus around five formal hypotheses, designed to explore the direct, indirect and conditional links between the variables:

Hypothesis 1 (Mediation): The authors hypothesise that *work engagement* acts as a key mediating mechanism in the relationship between OEHR practices (independent variable) and performance in creative tasks (dependent variable). According to this assumption, organisational opportunities function as external resources capable of activating work engagement, which, in turn, provides the cognitive energy necessary for creative output.

Hypothesis 2 (Moderation of Proactivity): It is hypothesised that the positive association between OEHR practices and *work engagement* is moderated and amplified by the employee's proactive personality trait. Specifically, the causal relationship is hypothesised to be significantly

stronger for workers with high levels of proactivity, as they are predisposed to make the most of the resources offered by the organisational context.

Hypothesis 3 (Moderation by Autonomy): The authors hypothesise that the direct relationship between *work engagement* and performance in creative tasks is moderated by job autonomy. It is anticipated that the positive association between the state of energetic activation and actual innovative behaviour will be more robust under conditions of high autonomy and operational discretion, compared to contexts characterised by rigid routines.

Hypothesis 4 (Moderated Mediation by Context): An overall moderated mediation effect is hypothesised, whereby the positive indirect association between OEHR practices and creative performance, mediated by *work engagement*, is influenced by levels of job autonomy. The effectiveness of resource-based HR practices reaches its peak exclusively in contexts of high job autonomy, fading where freedom of action is limited.

Hypothesis 5 (Individual Moderation): The theoretical model posits that the positive indirect association between OEHR practices and performance in creative tasks via *work engagement* is conditioned by, and greater for, employees with a strong proactive personality, capable of triggering a positive spiral of investment in their own personal resources.

To provide a comprehensive summary of the causal, mediating and moderating relationships analysed, the authors have integrated the theoretical framework and the five research hypotheses into a summary diagram.

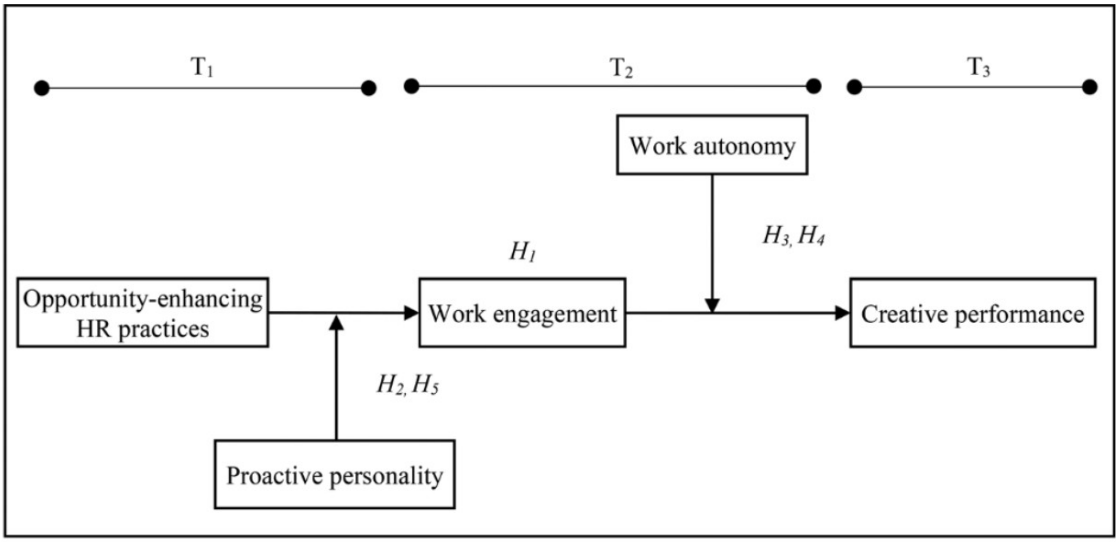


Figura 1. Modello concettuale proposto delle pratiche HR e delle prestazioni nei compiti creativi. T: Tempo. H1 mostra l'associazione indiretta mentre H_4 e H_5 mostrano mediazioni moderate.

Proposed conceptual model of HR practices and performance in creative tasks (Adapted from Gürbüz et al., 2024, p. 3772).

As can be seen from the graphical representation of the target model, the research framework introduces a precise temporal breakdown into three distinct waves (T1, T2 and T3). This design allows us to map the exact positioning of the moderating factors: proactive personality intervenes upstream to facilitate the transformation of HR practices into an active psychological resource (T1→T2), whilst job autonomy acts as the downstream boundary condition, necessary to unlock the potential of engagement into tangible creative behaviour (T2→T3).

2.2 Research Methodology

2.2.1 Participants, Procedure and Research Design

To empirically test the hypotheses of the conceptual model, the target study utilised data from the *Longitudinal Internet Studies for the Social Sciences* (LISS) panel, a specialist research organisation in the Netherlands managed by CentER data at Tilburg University. Members of this panel are selected through a true probability sampling procedure based on official registers from Statistics Netherlands. This methodological choice ensures a high level of

external validity and generalisability, as the sample under examination is not a convenience sample but rather a highly diverse and representative cross-section of the national working population.

From a research design perspective, the authors implemented a longitudinal study comprising three waves, spaced at regular intervals of eight weeks. This complex temporal structure addresses a specific psychometric and methodological need: the temporal separation in the measurement of independent, mediating and dependent variables significantly reduces the risk of *common-method bias* (CMB, Podsakoff et al., 2024), i.e. the systematic distortion of correlation coefficients due to the simultaneous administration of measurement instruments. Although the ideal time frame for observing the effect of HR practices on employee *outcomes* has not yet been defined (Griep et al., 2021), the authors emphasise that longitudinal studies confirm that changes in attitudes and internal psychological states emerge significantly even over short periods (Demerouti et al., 2012; Lu et al., 2014)

The data collection procedure followed a rigorous and sequential process. In the initial phase (T1), an online questionnaire was administered to a random sample of 597 employees working in organisations with at least 50 staff members, yielding 359 valid responses (a response rate of 60.13%) aimed at assessing OEHR practices, proactive personality and demographic control variables. In the second wave (T2), eight weeks later, the follow-up – which focused on measuring *work engagement* and job autonomy – was sent exclusively to respondents from the first phase, yielding 309 valid questionnaires (response rate of 86.01 per cent). Finally, in the third wave (T3), the final questionnaire on performance in creative tasks yielded 290 responses (response rate of 93.85 per cent).

The final sample, obtained following the removal of incomplete records and the matching procedure using unique anonymous codes, comprised 282 employees. In order to rule out threats to internal validity due to experimental attrition – that is, the phenomenon whereby a proportion of the initial participants decide not to complete subsequent questionnaires – the authors conducted an attrition analysis. Statistical tests (t-tests for independent samples) confirmed the absence of significant differences between those who completed the study and those who withdrew between T1 and

T3 with regard to key variables, such as gender, perceptions of HR practices and levels of proactive personality, thereby ruling out systematic biases in the sampling. The final sample of **282** employees reflects a heterogeneous composition: men account for 53.5 per cent of the sample (N=151), the mean age is 46.88 years (SD=12.23) and the mean length of service with the current employer is 13.31 years (SD=11.58). In terms of educational background, 77 per cent of participants hold a two-year degree or higher. Finally, with regard to contractual status and market positioning, 58.15 per cent work in for-profit organisations and the vast majority of the workforce surveyed (89.36 per cent) are covered by a permanent employment contract.

2.2.2 Measurement Instruments

To measure the constructs included in the theoretical model in practical terms, the authors selected five standardised psychological questionnaires. All the instruments share a common structure based on 5-point Likert-type response scales. Each scale is analysed in detail below:

- **HR Practices for Enhancing Opportunities (OEHR):** Assessed during the first time wave (T1), this macro-variable was measured using a composite scale comprising 11 items. Of these, 10 items were drawn from the standardised questionnaire by Prieto et al. (2012) to capture the dimensions of teamwork, information sharing and involvement in decision-making. In line with the recommendations of Kooij and colleagues (2022), the researchers included an eleventh item specifically designed to assess organisational flexibility
  . The response scale ranged from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). Cronbach's alpha coefficient stood at 0.87, indicating optimal internal consistency of the instrument.

- **Proactive personality:** This stable individual trait was assessed at T1 using the 6-item shortened version of the scale originally developed by Bateman and Crant (1993). Participants were asked to indicate their level of agreement (from 1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*) with

statements designed to gauge personal propensity for initiative and environmental change. The reliability of the scale showed a Cronbach's alpha value of 0.85, confirming robust internal consistency.

- **Work engagement:** Assessed at T2, this construct was measured using the ultra-brief *Utrecht Work Engagement Scale* (UWES-3) by Schaufeli and colleagues (2019), comprising just three items to assess vigour, dedication and absorption. The frequency of these feelings was rated on a scale from 1 (*never*) to 5 (*very often*). The internal consistency of the instrument was found to be good, with a Cronbach's alpha coefficient of 0.79.

- **Work autonomy:** Measured at T2 as a contextual moderator, autonomy in planning and operational methods was investigated using a 4-item scale adapted from Van Veldhoven and Meijman (1994). The items assessed the employee's perceived daily freedom in managing tasks, with responses ranging from 1 (*never*) to 5 (*very often*). The instrument demonstrated excellent internal consistency, with a Cronbach's alpha of 0.90.

- **Performance in creative tasks:** The final behavioural outcome (dependent variable) was measured in the last wave (T3) using a 5-item self-report instrument developed by Zhou and George (2001). The questions were designed to estimate the frequency with which the worker introduces innovative solutions in the workplace, on a Likert scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). The reliability index showed excellent internal consistency, with a coefficient α of 0.89.

- **Control variables:**

To isolate the impact of HR practices and psychological factors on performance, the researchers included age and gender (1 = male, 2 = female) as covariates at Time 1. This choice, supported by the literature (Atwater & Carmeli, 2009; Sauermann & Cohen, 2010), aims to control for the influence of demographic characteristics and experience on *engagement* and creative propensity.

2.2.3 Data Analysis Strategy

The statistical analysis of the collected data and the subsequent testing of the research hypotheses were carried out by the authors using a combination of two standard software packages in psychological research: **IBM SPSS 28** (used to calculate descriptive statistics, correlations and for regression tests) and **AMOS 28** (used specifically for Confirmatory Factor Analysis). The analysis process was structured in two sequential and complementary phases, aimed at ensuring the validity of the data before proceeding to calculate cause-and-effect relationships.

Phase 1: Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) and data validity check Before testing the research hypotheses, the authors had to carry out a 'quality check' on the data collected via questionnaires. As five different constructs were measured, many of which were conceptually similar, there was a risk that employees might have become confused when answering the questions. To demonstrate that the questionnaires did indeed measure five distinct concepts (*discriminant validity*), **a**
Confirmatory Factor Analysis (CFA) was carried out using AMOS 28.

To determine whether the theoretical model fitted the actual data well, the scores of the so-called fit indices were examined. According to the criteria established in the literature by Kline (2015), a model is considered valid if it simultaneously meets four mathematical rules: the chi-squared-to-degrees-of-freedom ratio (χ^2/df) must be less than 5, the CFI index must exceed the threshold of 0.90, whilst the RMSEA and SRMR error indices must remain below 0.08.

Subsequently, to ensure the validity of the data, the researchers employed a 'reductio ad absurdum' strategy: they forced the computer to analyse the data by deliberately aggregating the variables, creating three alternative, erroneous models (a 4-factor model

that combined practices and autonomy, a 3-factor model that combined measures taken at the same point in time, and a single-factor model that lumped all the questions together). This comparison confirmed that the five-factor model was the only correct one and, at the same time, ruled out the risk of *Common Method Bias* (CMB) – that is, the systematic distortion of data that occurs when participants' responses are correlated because they are influenced by a single transient state of mind (such as social desirability).

Stage 2: Testing hypotheses using regression models with the PROCESS macro Once it had been demonstrated that the questionnaires were valid and clearly distinct, the authors moved on to testing the cause-and-effect arrows of the model. To do this, they used Hayes' **PROCESS macro** for SPSS, an advanced tool based on multiple linear regression that allows for the integrated calculation of both *mediation* effects
(variables that act as bridges) and *moderation* effects (variables that act as amplifiers or switches).

Before commencing the moderation tests, the researchers applied a procedure to **centre the predictive and moderating variables around the mean**. This mathematical operation involves subtracting the mean score of the entire sample from each individual score. In this way, the value 'zero' coincides exactly with the sample mean, eliminating the mathematical problems of multicollinearity (statistical overlap that arises when the standardised questionnaire scores are multiplied together) and making the subsequent interaction graphs much easier to interpret.

PROCESS allows the selection of standardised models identified by specific numbers depending on the hypothesis to be tested:

1. **Model 4** was used to calculate the simple mediation effect, testing whether *work engagement* acts as a bridge between OEHR practices and creativity (**Hypothesis 1**).
2. **Model 1** was used to estimate simple moderations, analysing whether proactive personality amplifies the effect of workplace practices on engagement (**Hypothesis 2**) and whether autonomy enhances the effect of engagement on creativity (**Hypothesis 3**).
3. Finally, **Models 14 and 7** were chosen to test complex conditional processes, known as *moderated mediations*. These models assess whether the entire indirect pathway

(the flow from practices to creativity via the mediator) varies in intensity or is blocked depending on levels of autonomy (**Hypothesis 4**) or proactive personality (**Hypothesis 5**).

To determine whether the effects found were genuine and generalisable, the authors applied the computational technique of **non-parametric bootstrapping with 5,000 resamples**. This algorithm simulates the random extraction of 5,000 micro-samples from the actual data to recalculate the effect each time, generating a 95% confidence interval (95% CI) comprising a lower and an upper limit. According to the rules of inferential statistics, an effect is considered real and significant only if its confidence interval **does not include the value zero**. If the interval contains zero, this means that the effect is uncertain and null, leading to the rejection of the hypothesis.

2.3 Results

2.3.1 Results of the Confirmatory Factor Analysis Models

The authors carried out a preliminary check on the data using **Confirmatory Factor** Analysis in AMOS 28, the results of which are summarised in Table 1. By carrying out this test, the researchers mathematically demonstrated that: there is no overlap or confusion between questionnaires measuring similar concepts, and that the data are entirely free from *Common Method Bias* (CMB), i.e. they are not distorted by random responses or influenced by the moment of completion.

In accordance with the data analysis strategy outlined above, the researchers proceeded to validate the five-factor theoretical model using a comparative methodology based on the refutation of alternative hypotheses. Specifically, three deliberately flawed structural models were developed in order to compare their fit indices with those of the proposed model.

The five-factor model is illustrated below:

- **The five-factor model chosen by the authors (Model 1)** passed the CFA test, fully meeting the methodological criteria established in the literature by Kline (2015). Its fit to the actual data is confirmed by the following four statistical indices:

- **The Chi-squared to degrees of freedom ratio (χ^2/df):** the result is **2.08** (χ^2 = 760.68 divided by 365 df); as this is less than 5, the model was deemed to have passed with flying colours.
- **The CFI (Comparative Fit Index):** This measures the model's accuracy and requires a score above 0.90. The model achieved exactly **0.90**, meeting the validity threshold.
- **Error indices (SRMR and RMSEA):** These measure the level of inaccuracy in the data and must remain below the maximum limit of 0.08. The model recorded an **SRMR of 0.05** and an **RMSEA of 0.06**, placing it well below the tolerance threshold.

We now proceed to analyse the erroneous models:

- **The four-factor model (Model 2):** the authors artificially combined OEHR practices and job autonomy into a single factor to check whether employees confused them. All indices deteriorated: the CFI plummeted to **0.79**
, whilst measurement errors increased, recording an **SRMR of 0.08** and an **RMSEA of 0.09**. These findings demonstrate that HR practices and autonomy are two entirely distinct concepts in the minds of employees, thereby validating the five-factor model.
- **The three-factor model (Model 3):** The researchers grouped the variables according to when they were measured (one factor for all Time 1 measurements and one factor for those at Time 2). The results obtained were as follows: the CFI fell to **0.70**, the SRMR rose to **0.10** and the RMSEA to **0.11**. This demonstrates that collecting data across three distinct time waves, as in the model proposed by the authors, was the necessary procedure for the correct operationalisation of the constructs and to prevent statistical distortions.
- **The Single-Factor Model (Model 4):** This final test served to rule out the risk of *Common Method Bias* (CMB). The authors combined all items into a single factor.
The model collapsed, yielding the worst scores in the entire table: the CFI was **0.51**, the SRMR rose to **0.13** and the RMSEA to **0.14**. This demonstrates that grouping all items into a single
macro-dimension distorts the quality of the data, something which does not occur in the model proposed by the authors, confirming that respondents clearly distinguished between the

different concepts and that the research data are not compromised by the risk of *Common Method Bias*.

Tabella 1. I risultati dei modelli di analisi fattoriale confermativa.

						Confronto	
Modelli	χ^2	*df*	*CFI*	*SRMR*	*RMSEA*	ΔX^2	Δdf
1. Modello a cinque fattori	760,68***	365	0,90	0,05	0,06	–	–
modello a		369	0,79	0,08	0,09	2 contro 1	431,27*	4
2. Quattro fattori modello[b]	1192,07***						
3. Tre fattori modello[c]	1549,08***	372	0,70	10	11	3 contro 1	788,28*	7
4. Fattore singolo modello[d]	2327,07***	375	0,51	0,13	0,14	4 contro 1	1566,27**	10

N = 282. df: gradi di libertà; CFI: indice di adattamento comparativo; SRMR: radice quadrata media standardizzata dei residui; RMSEA ( ): radice quadrata media dell'errore di approssimazione.

[a] Il modello a cinque fattori proposto (ovvero pratiche OEHR, personalità proattiva, impegno lavorativo, autonomia lavorativa, e performance creativa).

[b] Sono state combinate le pratiche OEHR e l'autonomia lavorativa.

[c] Un fattore combinava le misure T1, comprese le pratiche HR e la personalità proattiva, l'altro fattore combinava le misure T2, compreso l'impegno lavorativo e l'autonomia lavorativa, e un altro fattore includeva la misura T3 dell' e: la performance creativa.

[d] Tutti gli elementi sono stati combinati.

* $p < 0,05$; ** $p < 0,01$; *** $p < 0,001$.

2.3.2 Descriptive statistics

The values for the means, standard deviations and Pearson's linear correlation coefficients between all the variables included in the model are set out in detail in Table 2. The results for the demographic control variables show that the participants' age exhibits some statistically significant relationships. Specifically, age is found to be weakly and positively correlated with both proactive personality ($r = 0.14$, $p < 0.01$) and *work engagement* ($r = 0.17$, $p < 0.01$). This statistical evidence suggests a generational trend within the organisational context under examination, indicating that employees with greater seniority tend to display slightly higher levels of proactivity and psychological engagement at work compared with their younger colleagues.

All the main relationships between the key constructs of the model run in the expected direction, showing positive and significant associations that justify the subsequent move to regression tests using the PROCESS macro.

Tabella 2. Medie, deviazioni standard e intercorrelazioni.

Variabili	*Media*	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6
1. T1 OEHR pratiche	3,35	0,60						
2. T1 Proattivo personalità	3,47	0,56	0,25**					
3. T2 Impegno lavorativo	3,57	0,69	0,36**	0,37				
4. T2 Lavoro autonomia	3,61	0,89	0,49**	0,38**	0,33**			
5. T3 Creative rendimento	2,93	0,81	0,27**	0,40**	0,28**	0,26**		
6. Genere (1 = maschi)	–	–	–0,10	–0,11	0,01	–0,22**	–0,07	
7. Età	46,88	12,23	0,03	0,14*	0,17**	0,10	–0,03	–0,04

(a due code). SD: deviazione standard; OEHR: pratiche HR che favoriscono le opportunità.
* $p < 0,05$; ** $p < 0,01$.

2.3.3 Testing Mediation and Moderation Hypotheses

Having established the validity of the questionnaires and analysed the initial correlations, the authors tested the five cause-and-effect hypotheses using Hayes's PROCESS macro regression models for SPSS. All analyses were conducted by including age and gender as control variables and applying the *bootstrapping* technique with 5,000 resamples to estimate 95% confidence intervals (95% CI). The complete numerical results of these tests are presented in Table 3 of the article.

Hypothesis 1, concerning the simple mediation of *work engagement* in the relationship between OEHR practices and creative performance, found full empirical support. The data indicate that OEHR practices positively predict work engagement ($b = 0.42$, $p < 0.001$) and that the latter has a significant impact on creative performance ($b = 0.26$, $p < 0.01$). The resulting indirect effect is **b = 0.11** (95% CI [0.04, 0.20]); the significance of the coefficient is confirmed by the absence of zero within the confidence interval. This dynamic highlights that the effectiveness of HR management systems depends on their ability to trigger work engagement, which acts as the necessary driver to transform the resources provided by the organisation into concrete creative outcomes.

Hypothesis 2 posited that the positive relationship between OEHR practices and *work engagement* would be amplified by employees' levels of proactive personality. The

results of the moderated regression analysis reveal a significant interaction effect (b=0.16, p<0.05), confirming the presence of moderation. An examination of the simple slopes shows that the impact of HR practices on work engagement holds true for the entire sample, but increases in intensity as proactive traits increase: the coefficient, in fact, ranges from a lower value for less proactive profiles ($b = 0.25$, $p < 0.01$) to an intermediate value for average profiles ($b = 0.34$, $p < 0.001$), before reaching its maximum strength in highly proactive individuals ($b = 0.43$, $p < 0.001$). From a practical perspective, the data indicate that proactivity acts as an individual catalyst: organisational engagement policies achieve the best results in terms of motivation when targeted at proactive staff, who are capable of fully recognising and capitalising on the opportunities offered by the organisation.

Hypothesis 3 examined whether the positive association between *work engagement* and performance in creative tasks was moderated and amplified by work autonomy. The results, derived using the same procedure as for the previous hypothesis, reveal a statistically significant combined interaction effect of $b = 0.19$ ($SE = 0.06$, $p < 0.01$, 95% CI [0.06, 0.30]), confirming the moderation hypothesis. The simple slope analysis reveals that the relationship between engagement and creativity varies according to the level of autonomy granted by the organisation: the effect is strongest under conditions of high job autonomy ($b = 0.47$, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI [0.20, 0.46]) and remains robust at moderate levels ($b = 0.31$, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI [0.12, 0.31]). Conversely, where there is low structural autonomy, the effect of engagement on innovative behaviour loses statistical significance (b=0.15, p=0.07, 95% CI [−0.01, 0.21]), as the confidence interval includes zero. From an organisational perspective, these findings suggest that autonomy in the workplace is an essential and decisive prerequisite: the motivational energy generated by engagement can only be translated into creative outcomes if the professional environment provides the operational and decision-making freedom necessary to express it.

Finally, the examination of the overall moderated mediation models (which assess the entire three-variable flow) yielded divergent results:

Hypothesis 4 extended the analysis to the entire moderated mediation mechanism (PROCESS Model 14), hypothesising that the positive indirect effect of OEHR practices on creative performance, mediated by *work engagement*, was conditioned by levels of workplace autonomy. The results confirm the hypothesis, showing an overall moderated mediation index

of **0.08** (SE=0.03, 95% CI [0.02, 0.13]). Conditional analysis reveals that the indirect effect is null when job autonomy is low (b = 0.04, 95% CI [−0.02, 0.12]), due to the presence of zero within the confidence interval. Conversely, the effect becomes significant at moderate levels of autonomy (b = 0.11, 95% CI [0.04, 0.20]) and reaches its maximum strength when autonomy is high (b = 0.19, 95% CI [0.08, 0.30]). In practical terms, the evidence shows that autonomy acts as an enabling factor: the effectiveness of HR practices is nullified if the organisation does not guarantee the operational freedom necessary to translate engagement into creative behaviours.

Hypothesis 5 examined the second model of moderate mediation (Model 7 of PROCESS), assuming that the positive indirect effect of OEHR practices on creative performance via *work engagement* would vary according to levels of proactive personality, being more intense for employees with high levels of proactivity. Statistical testing **rejected the hypothesis**, revealing an overall moderate mediation index that was not significant, equal to 0.04 (SE=0.04, 95% CI [−0.01, 0.14]). The lack of significance is confirmed by the fact that the bootstrap confidence interval contains zero. Consequently, the indirect effect does not vary in a statistically significant way amongst employees based on their level of proactivity. This finding suggests that, whilst a proactive personality is crucial in the early stages for increasing employees' initial levels of enthusiasm, it does not have sufficient influence to alter the entire process leading up to the final creative outcome.

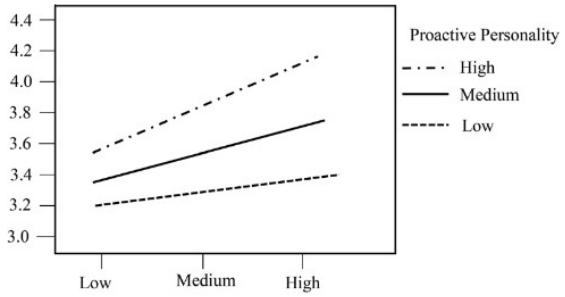


Figura 3. Grafico dell'interazione tra le pratiche OEHR e la personalità proattiva sull'impegno lavorativo.

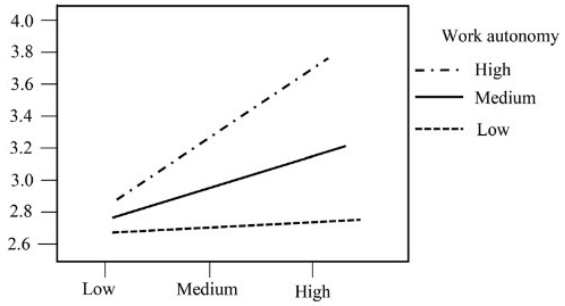


Figura 4. Grafico dell'interazione tra l'impegno lavorativo e l'autonomia lavorativa sulle prestazioni creative.

Table 3. Results of regression analyses including mediation, moderation and moderated mediation.

Paths	*b*	S£	*IC al 95%*
Hypothesis I (PROCESS Model 4, mediation)			
Path *a:* OEHR practices Work	B,42"°*	0.06	[0.29, 0.54]
Path b.: work commitment 4 creativity performance	B2ó	0.07	[0.12, 0.40]
Path c – OEHR4 practical sessions creativity performance	0,36***	O,D8	{0.08, 0.41)
Path *c' (direct effect):* OEHR practices Creative performance	0,25***	0.05	[0.05, 0.25]
EP Indirect path: OEHR4 work practices engagement in creative performance	B,11	0,04	[0.04, 0.20)
*Hypothesis 2 (*PPOC£SS f *model,* moderated by			
Interaction: OEHR" proactive practices personality work engagement	B,1ó"	0.07	[0.03, 0.30]
Non-proactive personality (I standard deviation at below the mean}	B.25""	0.07	1010, 0.39)
Average proactive penalisation (Average = B)	B.34""	0.06	[0.21, 0.46)
Highly proactive penalisation (I deviation standard deviation the mean}	B.43""	0.D7	[0.28, 0.57)
Hypothesis 3 PROCfS5 *Model* I, *moderation of*			
Interaction: Work commitment "Work" Autonomy4 Creative performance	0,19**	0.06	10.06, 0.30)
Low autonomy at work (1 standard deviation at below the mean)	0.15	0.08	[-0,B1, 0.21]
Average work autonomy (Mean = 0)	B.31""	0.07	{0.12, 0.3]
High work autonomy (1 standard deviation above the mean)	B,47"°*	0.10	[0.20, 0.46]
Hypothesis 4 *(PROCESS Model l4,* moderated *mediation*)			
Interaction: Work engagement* work autonomy –3• OEHR4 practices work engagement4 performance			
Moderated mediation index	B,08	0.03	(0.0Z, 0.13]
Low work autonomy (1 standard deviation below the (mean)	0,04	0.03	[-D, 0.02, 0.12]
Average work autonomy (Mean = 0)	011	0.04	(0.04, D, 20]
High work autonomy (1 standard deviation above the (mean)	0.19	0.06	(0.08, D, 30]
Hypothesis S *{Model P8OCfs57, moderated* mediation			
Interaction: OEHR practices × proactive 'personality'	OEHR4 practices	work engagement	creative performance
Moderated mediation index	B.04	B.04	[-D,0l, 0.1 #]
Low proactive penalisation {I standard deviation below the mean}	B,06	B.04	[-D,03, 0.08]
Average proactive penalty {Average = 0)	0.0g	0.04	[-D,0I, 0.09]
Highly proactive penalty (I deviation standard deviation the mean}	0.11	0.04	[-D, 0.02, 0.13]

Bootstrap resampling = 300D. b: Unstandardised coefficient; SE: Standard error; SD: Standard deviation; Cl: Upper and **lower** confidence intervals**;** OEHR: HR practices that improve opportunities. Age and gender were controlled for but not reported **for simplicity.**

' p < 0.05; "'P < 0.01; **°"P* < 0.001.

2.3.4 Discussion of the results

The results confirm that OEHR practices do not directly foster creativity, but rather through work engagement as a mediating mechanism: employees who perceive an environment rich in opportunities demonstrate greater work engagement and, consequently, more creative behaviour (indirect effect: b = 0.11, 95% CI [0.04, 0.20]). HR practices, however well designed, therefore require an active motivational state in the individual to translate into creative performance.

The two boundary conditions further clarify this picture. A proactive personality amplifies the relationship between OEHR practices and engagement (b = 0.43 for high proactivity vs. b = 0.25 for low): employees inclined to take the initiative recognise and capitalise more effectively on the opportunities offered by the organisation, triggering, in line with COR theory, a positive spiral of resource acquisition (Hobfoll et al., 2018). Work autonomy, on the other hand, acts downstream, between engagement and creativity: the relationship is significant under conditions of moderate autonomy (b = 0.31) and high autonomy (b = 0.47), but not under conditions of low autonomy (b = 0.15, p = 0.07). Even the most engaged worker encounters a structural limitation when they lack the freedom to choose how to manage their own work (Hackman and Oldham, 1976): motivation is a necessary but not sufficient condition in the absence of a context that allows it to be translated into innovative behaviour (Amabile et al., 2005).

2.4 Theoretical and practical implications

From a scientific perspective, the study's most significant contribution lies in clarifying the mechanism linking OEHR practices to creativity. Moving beyond traditional approaches based on social exchange theory (Cropanzano et al., 2017), the research demonstrates, through the lens of COR theory (Hobfoll, 1989, 2001) , that work engagement is the key mediator of this relationship: employees who perceive OEHR practices as work resources experience increased vigour, dedication and absorption, which translates into creative behaviour. In this sense, the study expands the literature on engagement by validating a sequential process in which HR practices centred on opportunities stimulate intrinsic motivation and, in line with the broaden-and-build theory (Fredrickson, 2013), expand the employee's repertoires of thought and action (Bakker et al., 2023). The identification of proactive personality and autonomy

The concept of the work environment as boundary conditions also responds to the call by Amabile and Pratt (2016) to explore the circumstances in which a supportive work environment effectively fosters creativity, enriching component theory with both dispositional and structural variables.

In practical terms, the findings offer concrete guidance for human resources professionals. Organisations aiming to stimulate innovation should implement OEHR practices such as involvement in decision-making, empowerment, flexible work arrangements and self-managed teams, complementing these with a leadership style capable of meeting the psychological needs for autonomy, growth and meaning (Schaufeli, 2021). Since the effectiveness of these practices depends in part on stable dispositional traits, recruitment processes should prioritise candidates with a distinctly proactive personality, whilst also rewarding personal initiative amongst existing staff (Fay & Frese, 2001). Finally, the data indicate that granting workers genuine freedom in managing their own tasks is not a minor detail, but a structural prerequisite without which even the most committed worker cannot realise their creative potential (Tims et al., 2013).

2.5 Limitations and suggestions for future research

The problem of self-report measures and response bias: The first limitation lies in the fact that all variables were measured through employees' self-assessment.
This method carries the risk that *Common Method Bias* may not have been entirely eliminated (Gürbüz & Şahin, 2018). Although the three-wave design minimises this risk, the presence of social desirability bias (Nederhof, 1985) and CMB (Podsakoff et al., 2024) remains possible, especially when employees assess their own creativity and proactivity. To address this, future research should employ triangulation methods using more objective measures, such as gathering feedback from line managers or calculating quantifiable assessments of the innovative ideas produced (Yang et al., 2021).

The issue of causality: Although data collection took place at three different points in time, the study cannot establish a definitive mathematical causality between the variables, as their baseline levels at earlier time points were not measured or controlled for. The authors therefore suggest the adoption of full panel designs or

field experiments to understand the exact causal order linking HR practices, work engagement and creative outcomes.

Limitation regarding HR packages: The study focused exclusively on OEHR practices, which represent only a part of high-performance HR systems (Prieto et al., 2012). Since different subsets of HR practices may trigger distinct pathways in determining performance, future studies should also include practices aimed at improving skills and extrinsic motivation, thereby broadening the general understanding of the topic (Liu et al., 2017; Ma et al., 2017).

Cultural generalisability: The sample consists solely of Dutch workers drawn from the LISS panel. As the effectiveness of OEHR practices depends heavily on the specific national and cultural context (Farndale & Sanders, 2017), the extent to which these findings can be applied to other countries remains uncertain. It is therefore recommended that, in future, the same model be tested in different cultural contexts to improve its external validity.

The impact of contextual factors: Finally, it cannot be taken for granted that increased creativity always translates into an automatic improvement in overall performance (Amabile & Pratt, 2016). There are, in fact, significant limiting conditions: in highly routine and task-oriented jobs, the immediate application of creativity may not yield tangible benefits. Conversely, in sectors that thrive on innovation, creativity represents the true driving force behind performance. The authors therefore call for future research to explore the factors linked to the sector and the nature of the work that may facilitate or hinder this link

CHAPTER 3 – THEORETICAL REFLECTIONS AND MULTIDISCIPLINAR L INTEGRATION OF THE RESULTS

3.1 The Job Demands-Resources model as a shared framework

The JD-R model posits that the characteristics of any work environment can be classified into two broad categories: job demands – that is, aspects of work that require sustained physical or psychological effort – and job resources – that is, elements that facilitate the achievement of objectives, reduce the cost of demands and promote personal growth. Two causal pathways emerge from this distinction: the health deterioration pathway, in which excessive demands lead to burnout and consequent negative outcomes, and the motivational pathway, in which resources foster work engagement and, through this, positive performance. This publication explicitly falls within this second pathway, treating HR practices aimed at enhancing opportunities (OEHR) as job resources and work engagement as a motivational mechanism that mediates the relationship with creativity

What makes this publication particularly significant from a training perspective is that it does not merely reproduce the model's classic framework, but enriches it by introducing two moderating variables – proactive personality and job autonomy – which add depth to our understanding of the motivational pathway. In this sense, the article engages with one of the most recent developments in the JD-R framework, namely the recognition that personal resources interact with job resources, amplifying their effect on engagement (Bakker et al., 2023). Seeing this theoretical extension applied to empirical data collected from a real-world sample has reinforced the understanding that the JD-R model is not a rigid structure, but a constantly evolving framework, capable of incorporating new variables and new research questions without losing its internal consistency.

3.2 Self-Determination Theory and the role of proactive personality

A second significant point of contact between the publication and the course of study concerns Self-Determination Theory (SDT; Deci & Ryan, 1985, 2000), which offers a complementary framework to the JD-R model for understanding the mechanism through which work-related resources translate into intrinsic motivation. SDT argues that intrinsic motivation arises when three fundamental psychological needs are

met: the need for autonomy, understood as the perception of being the source of one's own choices; the need for competence, that is, the feeling of being effective in one's interaction with the environment; and the need for relatedness, which concerns feeling connected to and meaningful to others (Ryan & Deci, 2000). OEHR practices, as described by Gürbüz et al. (2024), can be interpreted precisely as the structural conditions that make such fulfilment possible: involvement in decision-making fosters autonomy, flexible work design supports competence, and work in self-managed teams promotes relatedness.

However, the mere fact that these conditions exist within the organisation does not guarantee that every worker perceives and utilises them in the same way. It is here that the contribution of proactive personality becomes theoretically relevant. The proactive worker does not wait for resources to present themselves in an obvious way, but actively seeks them out and mobilises them: faced with an opportunity such as participation in decision-making processes, they tend to prepare themselves, propose solutions and demonstrate their competence, thereby transforming a neutral structural condition into a real subjective experience of autonomy and mastery. Conversely, a more passive worker may fail to translate the same resources into psychologically meaningful experiences, leaving unmet the needs that SDT identifies as the drivers of authentic engagement.

This line of reasoning is directly supported by the findings of the article, which show that the association between OEHR practices and work engagement is significantly stronger when proactivity is high than when it is low. Viewed through the lens of SDT, this finding suggests that proactivity acts as an amplifier of the fulfilment of psychological needs: it does not create the resources, but optimises the individual's ability to transform them into motivational nourishment.

3.3 The evolution of job design: from job enrichment to job -crafting

One of the most significant empirical findings in the paper by Gürbüz et al. (2024) concerns the role of autonomy at work: the results show that engagement translates into creativity only to a significant extent when employees perceive a high level of control over their work, whilst the effect disappears under conditions of low autonomy.
This finding takes on a specific historical depth: the question of how much freedom to grant workers runs through the entire history of organisational thought, and the answer that

each era has provided reflects radically different conceptions of human nature and performance.

Taylor's scientific organisation of work (1911) represents the starting point and, in some respects, the antithesis of everything demonstrated in this publication. In the Taylorist paradigm, autonomy is, by definition, zero: creativity, in this system, is a risk to be eliminated. Placing the findings of Gürbüz et al. within this historical context highlights just how much the conception of work has changed: what Taylor sought to eliminate is now identified as a necessary condition for one of the most valuable forms of performance in contemporary organisations. The first systematic response to the Taylorist model came with Hackman and Oldham's Job Characteristics Model (1976), which the authors of the article themselves cite as a reference for the conceptualisation of work autonomy. The model assigns autonomy a privileged role amongst job characteristics: it is autonomy that produces the perception of responsibility for the outcomes of one's own work, that is, the feeling of being the architect of one's own choices, which SDT refers to as the need for self-determination. In parallel, Trist's (1981) theory of socio-technical systems emphasised how optimal performance emerges from the integration of technical and social systems, attributing a central role to autonomous work groups. The most recent development
, and the one most directly linked to findings on proactive personality, is the shift towards job crafting (Wrzesniewski & Dutton, 2001; Tims et al., 2013). Whilst job enrichment was a top-down intervention designed by the organisation, job crafting describes a bottom-up process: it is the worker themselves who spontaneously modifies the boundaries of their role, seeking out more resources and increasing the number of stimulating demands. The proactive worker discussed in this article is, in essence, a job crafter: they do not wait for the organisation to offer them autonomy and opportunities for development, but actively construct them through their interaction with their environment. Proactivity and job crafting share the same underlying logic – the idea that the worker is not a passive recipient of organisational conditions, but an agent capable of shaping them – and, together, they explain why OEHR practices produce such varied effects depending on who perceives them.

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